

01

WHAT MAKES SOMETHING A RELIGION (if not God)? □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

A functional definition: religion = a way of life orienting one toward ultimate meaning, liberation, and the transcendent/absolute — which need not be a personal God. □□

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.

ANSWER LINE: ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM (Recommended opening definition): Religion is a disciplined orientation to an ultimate or sacred order through doctrine, practice, community and transformation; belief in a personal creator is not a necessary condition.

02

BUDDHISM as religion without God (2024 PYQ) □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhism is a complete non-creator religion because dependent origination explains suffering, the path disciplines life, the Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) sustains practice and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) supplies the final goal.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Buddhism is a complete non-creator religion because dependent origination explains suffering, the path disciplines life, the Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) sustains practice and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) supplies the final goal.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Yet fully a religion: it has the Four Noble Truths, the Eightfold Path, ethics (śīla), meditation, the Saṅgha, and a soteriology (nirvāṇa — liberation from dukkha). □

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Verdict: Buddhism decisively shows religion does not require God. □

ANSWER LINE: Buddhism is a complete non-creator religion because dependent origination explains suffering, the path disciplines life, the Saṅgha (Buddhist monastic and practitioner community) sustains practice and nirvāṇa (liberation from suffering) supplies the final goal.

WESTERN CRITIQUES OF (theistic) RELIGION □□

03

WESTERN CRITIQUES OF (theistic) RELIGION □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Nietzsche (2025 Q5(c) — □□ routed): "God is dead" — the belief in the Christian God has become unbelievable; traditional (esp.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Nietzsche challenge theistic religion respectively as projection, ideology, wish-fulfilment and a life-denying value-framework, but criticism of theism does not by itself construct a religion without God.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

Christian) morality is a "slave morality" born of resentment, life-denying, exalting weakness.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Nietzsche challenge theistic religion respectively as projection, ideology, wish-fulfilment and a life-denying value-framework, but criticism of theism does not by itself construct a religion without God.

ANSWER LINE: Feuerbach, Marx, Freud and Nietzsche challenge theistic religion respectively as projection, ideology, wish-fulfilment and a life-denying value-framework, but criticism of theism does not by itself construct a religion without God.

04

AGNOSTICISM (2023 PYQ) □

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Agnosticism (Huxley): the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable — we should suspend judgement (distinct from atheism, which denies God). □

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

Agnosticism (Huxley): the claim that the existence of God is unknown or unknowable — we should suspend judgement (distinct from atheism, which denies God). □

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; unlike atheism, it withholds assent rather than asserting denial.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; unlike atheism, it withholds assent rather than asserting denial.

ANSWER LINE: Agnosticism suspends judgement about God's existence or knowability; unlike atheism, it withholds assent rather than asserting denial.

05

STATEMENT / QUOTE BANK □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. □ Nietzsche: "God is dead... and we have killed him."

05

STATEMENT / QUOTE BANK □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

1. □ Nietzsche: "God is dead... and we have killed him."

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

4. □ Buddhist: the world runs by dependent origination — no first cause/creator needed.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. □ Feuerbach: God is the projected essence of man — "theology is anthropology."

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

Answer-use: 1. □ Nietzsche: "God is dead... and we have killed him."

ANSWER LINE: 1. □ Nietzsche: "God is dead... and we have killed him."

06

APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

2. [Nietzsche] "Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality." (2025, 10m) → □□ primary owner is Religion and Morality §9.6; use §3/§9.4 here only for the post-theistic bridge.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. [Nietzsche] "Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality." (2025, 10m) → □□ primary owner is Religion and Morality §9.6; use §3/§9.4 here only for the post-theistic bridge.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. [Agnosticism] "What is agnosticism?"

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

5. [Cārvāka] "Cārvāka's critique of belief in suprasensible entities." (2025, 10m) → §9.6 — the vyāpti argument is the answer, not the hedonism.

ANSWER LINE: 1. [Buddhism] "State & evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God." (2024, 20m) → §2 + §9.2.

07

THE FIVE WAYS OF DOING WITHOUT GOD — parity bench □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

ANSWER LINE: 1. □ Nietzsche: "God is dead... and we have killed him."

APPLIED-QUESTION DRILLS □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

2. [Nietzsche] "Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality." (2025, 10m) → □□ primary owner is Religion and Morality §9.6; use §3/§9.4 here only for the post-theistic bridge.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

2. [Nietzsche] "Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality." (2025, 10m) → □□ primary owner is Religion and Morality §9.6; use §3/§9.4 here only for the post-theistic bridge.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

3. [Agnosticism] "What is agnosticism?"

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

5. [Cārvāka] "Cārvāka's critique of belief in suprasensible entities." (2025, 10m) → §9.6 — the vyāpti argument is the answer, not the hedonism.

ANSWER LINE: 1. [Buddhism] "State & evaluate Buddhism as a religion without God." (2024, 20m) → §2 + §9.2.

THE FIVE WAYS OF DOING WITHOUT GOD — parity bench □□

CONTEXT + EXACT CORE

Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER USE

ANSWER-GRABBING LINE — WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.

ANSWER LINE: Non-theistic traditions replace different divine functions separately—creation, authority, moral causation, worship or salvation—so 'religion without God' names several arguments rather than one model.